

ANSWERING WRITING QUESTIONS (for those who still aren't good at it)

NOTE: These are for people who do not understand how to answer the questions the right way. The best mode of approach for any question is to go through your grammar rules. Only follow these rules if you still don't understand grammar rules.

Boundaries

Need to know: the four possible punctuations than can combine two independent clauses, the "pattern"

Four Punctuations:

- Period (.)
- Semi-colon (;)
- Colon (:)
- Comma+Conjunction (, conj)

The "Pattern":

The "Pattern" refers to the answer choices that include nothing, a comma, a conjunction, and one of the four punctuation marks used to combine independent clauses (which is why you need to know them).

Ex.

- | | | |
|-----|--------------|---------------|
| A.) | house he | [nothing] |
| B.) | house, he | [comma] |
| C.) | house but he | [conjunction] |
| D.) | house; he | [IC + IC] |

Ex.

- | | | |
|-----|------------|---------------|
| A.) | food: | [IC + IC] |
| B.) | food, | [comma] |
| C.) | food while | [conjunction] |
| D.) | food | [nothing] |

Whenever you encounter the "pattern", the correct answer is usually the choice that contains the punctuation that combines two independent clauses. If you do not know how to prove what the answer is, then **you should snap pick the [IC + IC] choice and move on.**

NOTE: Sometimes, the SAT will intentionally make the first clause dependent, in which case the correct answer requires the [comma]. If you know your subordinating conjunctions, you can easily prove this (because, while, as, though, that, which, when, where, why, what, etc...).

Subject Verb Agreement

1.) Type 1: Agreement (Plurality)

Need to know: what singular and plural verbs look like

Singular (ends in “s”)

is
was
has
does
runs
is running
has left

Plural (doesn’t end in “s”)

are
were
have
do
run
are running
have left

NOTE: When the verb contains an auxiliary verb, it is the auxiliary that must be plural or singular

NOTE: some tenses do not change based on agreement (this is why you should memorize your tenses).

Whenever your answer choices contain three answers of one plurality and one of the other, **you should pick the one that is different.**

Ex.

A.) are	plural
B.) were	plural
C.) have been	plural
D.) was	singular

Ex. (“not” is an adverb, not a verb)

A.) hasn’t been	singular
B.) wasn’t	singular
C.) isn’t	singular
D.) aren’t	plural

Ex. (verbs that naturally end in an “s” end in an “es” when they are singular)

A.) focus s	singular
B.) focus	plural
C.) are focused	plural
D.) were focused	plural

2.) Type 2: Does it have a Subject?

Need to know: what tenses do not have a subject, what tenses do

Tenses that **NEVER** have a subject:

Infinitives:

to be
to do
to have
to run
to go

Present participles (w/o an auxiliary verb):

being
doing
having left
running
going

Tenses that **SOMETIMES** have a subject:

Past participle (w/o an auxiliary verb):

wanted
needed
read
defeated

Tenses that **ALWAYS** have a subject:

Simple tenses

is
are
have
ran

Anything w/ an auxiliary/modal verb

will be
had been
could have been
can be
is going
had needed

Whenever your answers choices contain three answer that do/don't need a subject and one that doesn't/does, **you should pick the one that is different.**

Ex.

- | | |
|-------------------|--------------|
| A.) to rain | [no subject] |
| B.) raining | [no subject] |
| C.) having rained | [no subject] |
| D.) rain | [subject] |

Ex.

- | | |
|--|--------------|
| A.) Union would finally acknowledge | [subject] |
| B.) Union to finally acknowledge | [no subject] |
| C.) Union, hav ing finally acknowledged | [no subject] |
| D.) Union, finally acknowledg ing | [no subject] |

NOTE: Commas directly before the verb (especially a past or present participle) are a dead giveaway that the verb does not have a subject.

Ex.

- | | |
|---------------------|--------------|
| A.) is | [subject] |
| B.) being | [no subject] |
| C.) was | [subject] |
| D.) is being | [subject] |